

Practice Paper 13 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “A quick clutch in my stomach”

1 mark for identifying a sudden **physical reaction of fear or shock**; **1 mark** for explaining the cause — the realisation that what he had thought was rubbish was a living creature in distress.

Sample answer: The phrase suggests that the narrator felt a **sudden jolt of fear and worry**, because he had just realised that the small object was alive and possibly hurt, and this discovery startled him deeply.

Q2. [2] — “A wrong, terrible angle”

1 mark for identifying the **simile / comparison** to a careless hand.

1 mark for explaining the effect — the wing looks **unnaturally positioned**, as though it has been **mishandled** and **left wrong**, which makes the injury feel **deliberate, cruel** and **more pitiful**.

Q3. [1] — Other boys unaware

1 mark — Any **one** of:

- They were “already halfway to the canteen”.
- They were “shouting about chicken rice” (their attention was elsewhere).
- “None of them had seen.”

Q4. [2] — Why he does not tell Mr Tham (own words)

1 mark each for any two of:

- Mr Tham had once **shouted at him** at length over a small matter (kicking a ball into the flowers), so the narrator is **afraid of him**.
- The narrator believes Mr Tham **dislikes small, vulnerable creatures**.
- He fears Mr Tham would **handle the bird roughly** / throw it into the bin and let it die.

Reject answers that lift “did not like small, frightened things” without rewording.

Q5. [2] — Three short sentences / warmth

(a) [1]: The **short, clipped sentences** slow the narrative down and force the reader to **pause on each new realisation**, mirroring how the boy is processing the bird **one sensation at a time**. They also convey his **quiet wonder / tenderness**.

(b) [1]: He may have expected a wounded or near-dead bird to feel **cold** or **limp**; the **warmth** is a sudden, almost shocking reminder that the sparrow is **truly alive** and **still has a life worth saving**.

Q6. [2] — Wei Lun’s character (contrast)

1 mark for identifying the **contrast** between his usual bored expression and his sudden seriousness.

1 mark for explaining what this reveals — Wei Lun has a **hidden capacity for care / responsibility**, which the narrator has not seen before; he is **not as indifferent as he appears**.

Q7. [2] — “He was not asking me. He was telling me what to do.”

1 mark — The **two short, parallel sentences** create a **strong, decisive rhythm** that mirrors Wei Lun’s **calm authority**.

1 mark — The **repetition of “He was”** and the **negative-then-positive** structure (**not asking / telling**) **emphasises** the shift from question to command, making Wei Lun seem **confident** and **in charge**.

Q8. [2] — “Both very small and very grown up” (own words)

1 mark — **Very small**: He feels **childish / inexperienced / humbled** in the presence of someone older who clearly knows more than he does.

1 mark — **Very grown up**: At the same time, he feels he is being **trusted with an important task / taking part in something serious and adult**, which makes him feel mature beyond his years.

Q9. [2] — “Used the word **perhaps** very gently”

1 mark — The writer draws attention to one word to **highlight its weight**: “perhaps” **softens** what the man is really saying.

1 mark — It suggests the man is **gently warning** the narrator that the bird **may not survive**, without saying so directly — he is being **kind** and **protective of a child’s hope**.

Q10. [2] — Impression of the adult narrator

1 mark — A reasonable impression: **reflective, compassionate, thoughtful, gentle, changed by the experience**.

1 mark — **One** supporting detail from Paragraph 8, e.g.:

- The memory has “stayed with me for a long time” (he has not forgotten).
- He calls it “the first day I understood” (he marks it as a turning point).

- He recognises caring is “not, by itself, enough to keep it alive” (he draws a mature lesson).
- He calls the painful realisation “its own kind of beginning” (he sees growth, not only loss).

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any one of: **reflective, bittersweet, thoughtful, wistful, resigned but accepting.**
(Reject: **bitter, angry, happy** — these miss the contemplative quality.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “A kind of last wilderness”

1 mark for understanding **wilderness** — an untouched, natural place not yet altered by humans.

1 mark for understanding **last** — the **final** such place left on Earth, suggesting people believed the deep ocean was **beyond human reach** and **safe from pollution**.

Q13. [2] — “Every single specimen”

1 mark — It shows the contamination is **not occasional or rare** but **universal** among the creatures examined.

1 mark — It emphasises the **scale and seriousness** of the problem: even animals living in total darkness, far from people, are affected — proving plastic has reached the most remote parts of the ocean.

Q14. [2] — “A slow, dark blizzard”

1 mark — The **metaphor / image** of a blizzard suggests something **continuous, drifting downward, and inescapable**.

1 mark — It implies plastic reaches the seabed **constantly and quietly**, mixed with natural marine particles, so the pollution is **steady** and **invisible** rather than a single dramatic event.

Q15. [2] — Two ways plastic from land reaches the deep ocean (own words)

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Litter dropped on a beach** is washed into the sea.
- **Fishing equipment** (e.g. abandoned nets) is left in the water and drifts down.
- **Worn-down particles from car tyres** on inland roads make their way through drains and rivers to the sea.
- Plastic is **eaten by surface fish** that later die and sink, carrying it downwards.

Reject answers that list “biofilms” / “marine snow” without rewording.

Q16. [2] — Why location makes the problem difficult (own words)

1 mark — The microplastics are **kilometres below the sea surface**, far beyond the reach of any practical recovery vessel.

1 mark — They are **scattered across an enormous area** (the size of a continent) and **mixed with sand and natural material**, so even if cleanup were possible, it would **damage the very ecosystems** it was meant to protect.

Q17. [1] — Inverted commas around “biodegrade”

1 mark — The inverted commas indicate that the word is being used **sceptically / ironically** — plastic does **not actually biodegrade** in the way people assume; it only **fragments** into smaller pieces. The marks distance the writer from a **misleading** term.

Q18. [2] — Effect of “no longer ‘away’”

1 mark — The **short, blunt sentence** contrasts with the longer, more technical sentences before it, providing **strong closing emphasis**.

1 mark — The **inverted commas** around “away” highlight a **common assumption** — that rubbish thrown out simply disappears — and reject it: the chemicals come **back to us** through the food chain, so there is **no such place as “away”**.

Q19. [2] — Imperfect treaties / serious admission

(a) [1]: Any **one** of:

- Their **targets are contested**.
- Their **timetables are long** (slow).
- The **willingness** of large plastic-producing nations to bind themselves is **uncertain**.

(b) [1]: He means it is the **first major formal acknowledgement** at the international level that the deep ocean **belongs to all nations** and must be **protected by all nations** — previously it was treated as no one’s responsibility.

Q20. [2] — Attitude towards individual action

1 mark — He is **sympathetic / respectful** towards people who make individual green choices — he does **not mock** them.

1 mark — However, he is **realistic / measured**: he believes such efforts are **not sufficient on their own** and must be matched by **systemic change**. (Accept: balanced, even-handed, gently dismissive of the **idea** but not the **people**.)

Q21. [2] — “Did not arrive there by accident”

1 mark — The **contrast** between “accident” and “a long chain of choices” **rejects the comforting idea** that the pollution is random or no one’s fault.

1 mark — It **places responsibility** squarely on **human decisions** (in design, sale, use and disposal), and so prepares the reader for the writer’s argument that systemic **redesign** — not luck — is what is needed.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.

Why deep-sea plastic pollution is hard to deal with (Paragraphs 3–4 & 6):

1. The plastic lies **kilometres beneath the surface**, far beyond the reach of any practical vessel.
2. It is **spread across an enormous area** and **mixed with sand and natural debris**, so retrieval would be near impossible.
3. Attempting to recover it would **damage the very ecosystems** one is trying to protect.
4. Plastic does **not biodegrade** — it only **breaks into smaller pieces**, releasing harmful chemicals.
5. These chemicals **move up the food chain**, eventually entering humans.
6. The **sheer scale of production** — half of all plastic was made in the last 20 years and output is set to double by 2040 — **overwhelms individual efforts**.

What is being done internationally (Paragraph 5):

7. The **UN Global Plastics Treaty** (2022) aims to set **binding targets** on plastic production, design and waste.
8. The **High Seas Treaty** (2023) allows **marine protected areas** to be created in international waters.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Deep-sea plastic pollution is hard to deal with because the waste lies kilometres down, spread across vast areas and mixed with sediment, so any cleanup would damage the ecosystem it aimed to save. Plastic does not break down; it splinters, releasing chemicals that climb the food chain into humans. Production keeps doubling, dwarfing personal effort. Internationally, the UN Plastics Treaty seeks binding limits on production, while the High Seas Treaty allows protected zones in once-ungoverned waters.

Length count: 78 words from “Deep-sea” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —